

PRE-HISTORIC ROCK ART OF EUROPE AND UGANDA

Prehistoric art refers **artifacts** made before there was a written record. Long before the oldest written languages were developed, people had become expert at creating forms that were both practical and beautiful.

Artifacts are objects made by human beings for cultural or historical interest. They include art, tools, and clothing made by people of anytime and place.

Early humans made various images in form of drawings, painting and sculpture. Such artwork is what we call prehistoric art. The prehistoric man basically lived in caves and therefore most of his painting and drawings were done on cave walls and ceilings.

The three main art forms were **cave painting, rock engraving and miniature figurative carvings.**

Prehistoric art periods

The prehistoric period is divided into Paleolithic and Neolithic periods.

The Paleolithic period (60,000 – 10,000 BC)

Paleolithic or Old Stone Age began from the first production of stone artifacts. This happened from about 2.5 million years ago to the end of the last ice age 9,600BC. Ice age was a period when thick ice sheets covered large areas of land. During this period, Paleolithic age hominins grouped together in small societies called bands. They gathered plants, fished, and hunted wild animals. Hominins were a tribe of primates. They were any species of early humans that is closely related more to humans than chimpanzees, including modern humans.

During the Paleolithic or Old Stone Age era, two main categories of art were produced: portable pieces such as figurines or decorated objects and cave art. The portable art was carved out of bone, antler, or stone, or modeled in clay. It has been found much in Europe, in Northern Africa, and in Siberia. Cave art, discovered primarily in Northern Spain and Southern France, takes the form of paintings, drawings, and engravings on cave walls.

The Neolithic Period (9,000-3,000 BC)

Neolithic period or New Stone age

Neolithic period was a transition from the old ways to new ways of living. In this period humans started living together in societies and villages. They formed simple structures for living in and made more tools for survival. They abandoned the semi nomadic life of gathering food and hunting and adopted farming and animal husbandry.

Prehistoric Rock Art in Europe

Prehistoric Rock Art is the art of the first Europeans. It appeared in Europe 42,000 years ago and developed throughout the Paleolithic, and Neolithic periods, the copper and the bronze Ages until the Early Iron Age in some regions.

Prehistoric rock art in Europe is mainly found in France and Spain. More than 300 caves with **parietal art** including painting, drawing and carving from prehistoric times have been discovered in Spain and France. Other European countries with prehistoric art include Portugal, England, Italy, Germany, Russia and Romania. There are major Paleolithic rock art sites and these include Lascaux rock art site, Chauvet-Pont d'art cave in France and the cave of Altamira in Spain.

characteristics of prehistoric art according to periods

Paleolithic (Old Stone Age - c. 40,000 BCE - 10,000 BCE):

- Focus on animal depictions like bison, horses, deer, mammoths
- Life-like profiles and motion shown in animals
- Use of cave walls and ceilings, artifacts like figurines
- Simplistic human representations
- Handprints common
- Signs, dots, dashes for possible early writing

Neolithic (New Stone Age - c. 10,000 BCE - 4,500 BCE):

- Increasing stylization and abstraction of figures
- More attention to human form and early facial features
- Use of megalithic structures like Stonehenge
- Geometric designs and early symbols emerge
- Clay used for figurine and pottery creation

Bronze Age (c. 3300 BCE - 1200 BCE):

- Intricate bronze, gold, silver metalworking developing
- Stylized representations in metalwork
- Weapons and jewelry crafted
- Emergence of urns, bowls and vessels
- Megalithic tomb traditions continue
- Rock carvings for writing and symbols

Prehistoric art in Europe:

- The earliest known prehistoric art in Europe dates back to the Stone Age over 40,000 years ago. Some of the earliest examples are figurines, carvings, and cave paintings created by Stone Age hunter-gatherers.

- Cave paintings found in places like Lascaux and Altamira in France and Spain show depictions of animals, human hands, and abstract symbols. These were made using mineral pigments like iron oxide, charcoal, and manganese.
- Other prehistoric art media include ivory carvings, clay figurines like the Venus of Willendorf, megalithic structures like Stonehenge, and intricate goldwork.
- Different prehistoric cultures had unique styles. Paleolithic art focused on animals, hunting scenes, and the female form. Neolithic art showed the beginnings of farming and settled lifestyles. Bronze Age art displayed more stylized, geometric designs.
- Prehistoric art had purposes ranging from magic and ritual to recording history and everyday life. The meaning and messages conveyed were deeply significant for those prehistoric peoples.
- Around 10,000 BCE, prehistory transitions into ancient history as civilizations emerge. However, prehistoric artistic traditions remained and evolved across different regions and periods.

Nyero rock art in Uganda:

- The Nyero rock shelter is located in Kumi district in eastern Uganda.
- It contains some of the most vivid and well-preserved prehistoric rock art in Uganda, dating back over 1,000 years.
- The site has about 55 panels of paintings made with red, white, and yellow pigments.
- Subjects include long-horned cattle, antelopes, giraffes, elephants, human figures, geometrical shapes, and handprints.
- The paintings depict day-to-day life including hunting, dancing, community gatherings, and pastoral scenes.
- One unique painting shows a traditional house with women grinding millet and brewing beer inside.
- The art provides insight into the Late Stone Age hunter-gatherer and pastoralist inhabitants of the region.
- The pigments used were made from hematite, clay, and guano. Brushes were created from twigs.
- The paintings are estimated to be around 2,000 - 4,000 years old based on stylistic analysis.
- Nyero indicates some of the earliest domestication of cattle in the region.
- The site was rediscovered in the 1950s and excavations began in the 1980s led by archaeologist Peter Schmidt.
- Nyero demonstrates the advanced artistic skills of Uganda's prehistoric peoples and is considered a culturally significant heritage site in the country.

Development of ancient Egyptian art:

- Early Egyptian art emerged in the Predynastic period starting around 4000 BCE. Simple pottery and crafts depicted images of animals and people.

- During the Early Dynastic Period (c. 3100-2686 BCE), art focused on representing royalty. Palette of King Narmer shows figures in profile and hierarchical scale.
- Old Kingdom (c. 2686-2181 BCE) saw huge advances as pyramid complexes were built. Reliefs, statues, and paintings adorned tombs of pharaohs and nobility.
- Art became more stylized in the Middle Kingdom (c. 2030-1650 BCE). Painting used flattened figures and more angular poses. Scribes and everyday life depicted.
- New Kingdom (c. 1550 - 1070 BCE) art had greater realism and detail. Colossal statues of pharaohs were built. Murals showed military battles and religious rituals.
- Late Period (c. 664 - 332 BCE) art copied earlier styles. Emphasis on religion - Gods and goddesses focused on more in temple reliefs and wall paintings.
- Common subjects were Pharaohs, gods, afterlife, rituals, symbols of power. Art was symbolic, symmetrical, idealized - aimed to preserve order and tradition.
- Egyptian art focused on permanence, with rigid artistic rules. Canon of proportions and profile view persisted across millennia, but styles also evolved over time.
- Fundamental artistic elements like hieroglyphs, obelisks, sphinxes had longevity and continuity. Art played a pivotal role in ancient Egyptian culture.

Ancient Egyptian architecture:

- Egyptian architecture emphasized permanence, solidity, and monumentality. Stone was the primary construction material.
- Ancient Egyptian architects mastered techniques like post and lintel construction to create structures able to withstand the elements.
- Pyramids exemplify the apex of ancient Egyptian architecture. The pyramids of Giza are marvels of engineering and symbolized royal power.
- Egyptian temples had distinctive sloped walls, massive columns, impressive statuary, and obelisks, like in the Luxor Temple complex.
- Advances in architecture expanded under the Old and New Kingdom periods as Egypt's power grew. More complex temple and tomb designs emerged.
- Architectural symmetry and visual harmony were emphasized - styles followed rigid rules governed by tradition and symbolism.
- Interior temple spaces used impressive columns, hypostyle halls, ramps, and pylons, often decorated with hieroglyphs, paintings, and reliefs.
- Mortuary complexes grew in scale - valley temples, causeways, cult pyramids, and mortuary temples were built near royal pyramids.
- Egyptian architecture influenced future cultures. Greco-Roman styles incorporated Egyptian elements like obelisks, sphinxes, and temple layouts.

Key aspects of ancient Egyptian art:

Purpose - Art was functional and symbolic, used to maintain order, honor gods/pharaohs, and provide for the afterlife.

Style - Art was fairly rigid and standardized with strict conventions. Figures in profile view, hierarchical scale, idealized beauty.

Mediums - Painting, sculpture, architecture, reliefs, hieroglyphs. Materials included stone, wood, paints, metal.

Subjects - Depictions of pharaohs, gods and goddesses (Ra, Osiris, Isis), rituals, the afterlife, symbols of power.

Characteristics - Symmetry, order, permanence. Followed rules of proportions and iconography. Focused on stability.

Principles - Egyptians believed art was magical, a way to overcome death. Artworks followed canon of principles.

Development - Art evolved across kingdoms but kept Egyptian identity. New styles emerged yet traditions continued.

Influences - Art represented religious beliefs, Nile resources, royal authority. Shaped by invention of writing.

Legacy - Egyptian artistic motifs inspired later cultures. Art's purpose and grand scale left lasting impact.

Key elements and principles evident in ancient Egyptian art:

Elements:

- **Line** - Precise, fluid lines used to outline figures and objects in two-dimensional reliefs and paintings. Defined contours and shapes.
- **Shape** - Figures and objects depicted with simple, symmetrical shapes like rectangles, squares and triangles.
- **Color** - Vivid colors like blue, red, green, gold used in a symbolic way. Darker shades emphasized male figures.
- **Texture** - Smooth, idealized textures seen in statues. Stone textures added naturalism in reliefs.
- **Space** - Flat, floating space used with overlapping to indicate depth. Figures sized by hierarchy.

Principles:

- **Balance** - Bilateral (mirror) symmetry created visual harmony and order.
- **Proportion** - Canon of proportions followed for idealized human figures. Rules guided artistic compositions.
- **Unity** - Repetition of themes, subject matter unified art across different works and periods.
- **Rhythm** - Repeating motifs and patterns (hieroglyphs, shapes) created movement.
- **Emphasis** - Central figures like the pharaoh made the focus through scale and placement.

Examples of major art forms from ancient Egypt and the social/cultural values they conveyed:

- Pyramids - Massive tomb and mortuary complex for pharaohs. Conveyed importance of pharaoh's role, belief in afterlife, royal power.
- Temples - Elaborate structures dedicated to gods. Centers of economic and social life. Showcased religious beliefs, rituals.
- Sphinx - Mythical sculpture with head of a pharaoh and lion's body. Symbol of strength and divine wisdom.
- Obelisks - Tall, four-sided tapering monuments inscribed with dedications. Honored sun gods, inspired awe.
- Paintings - Found in tombs, temples, papyri. Depicted gods, pharaohs, rituals, daily life. Expressed values, culture.
- Hieroglyphics - Formal writing system with symbols. Recorded history, beliefs, ideas. Highly symbolic.
- Jewelry - Crafted in gold, gems. Signified social status, wealth. Reflected artistic skill, craftsmanship.
- Canopic jars - Contained organs removed during mummification. Part of rituals for the afterlife.
- Palette of King Narmer - Early carving depicting pharaoh's victory, status. Shows unified Egypt.

Some key social, technological, and cultural developments in ancient Egyptian civilization:

Social:

- Hierarchical society, with pharaoh at the top. Nobles, scribes, priests, craftsmen, farmers, slaves under him.
- Highly organized bureaucracy to manage complex infrastructure.
- Skilled division of labor - artisans, embalmers, laborers had specialized roles.
- Social customs emphasizing cleanliness, family life, etiquette recorded.
- Women had rights to property, divorce, served as regents. But men dominated.

Technological:

- Agro-technological advances - irrigation, plows, winnowing helped farming.
- Construction innovations enabled feats like pyramids through ramps, levering.
- Materials like papyrus, ink, pigments used in record-keeping and art.
- Fine jewelry craftsmanship - used lost wax casting, filigree, cloisonné.
- Medicine, dentistry, anatomy studied through mummification processes.

Cultural:

- Religion focused on gods, the afterlife. Elaborate rituals and priesthood.
- Formal writing system using hieroglyphs, numbering system. Scribes trained.
- Burial practices like mummification tied to belief in afterlife.
- Love for art and architecture seen in paintings, sculpture, monuments.

- Literature like moral teachings, poetry, hymns composed.

Ancient Egyptian sculpture

- Egyptian sculpture emerged in the late Predynastic period, gained prominence in the Early Dynastic period, and peaked during the Old, Middle, and New Kingdoms.
- The most common form was statuary depicting gods, pharaohs, and nobility. Statues were meant to provide a resting place for the ka or spirit.
- Sculptures were highly symbolic and idealized. They adhered to artistic conventions like frontal torso, profile face, symmetrical proportions.
- Common mediums were stone (granite, limestone, sandstone), wood, ceramic/clay, and metal like copper and bronze.
- Subjects depicted divinities, kings, queens, scribes, nobles. Gods were shown with animal heads attached to human bodies.
- Notable sculptural forms include Sphinxes, Obelisks, Figurines like Ushabtis placed in tombs.
- Skilled techniques used were carving, modeling, casting, engraving, and inlaying precious stones and metals.
- Some colossal works depicted tremendous size and power, like the Great Sphinx of Giza.
- Signature styles emerged during different periods - more rigid in Old Kingdom, relaxed in Middle Kingdom.
- Funerary masks covered the head of mummified bodies to represent the person in the afterlife.

Ancient Egyptian drawing and painting:

- Used for architectural decoration, manuscripts, funerary contexts to depict gods, rituals, pharaohs.
- Earliest paintings date to 3000 BCE on pottery and walls of tombs, pyramids.
- Bold outlines, flat shapes, profile faces, composite view - all bodies shown frontally.
- Mineral pigments provided rich colors - blue, black, green, gold, red dominated.
- Shading and modeling rare. Perspective or realism not shown as art was symbolic.
- Scenes portray activity, events - hunting, farming, military, religious rituals depicted.
- Figures organized hierarchically - pharaohs and gods shown larger than others.
- Paint applied to prepared plaster and mud surfaces in tombs, temples, coffins.
- Brushes made of rush and palm, pigments ground and mixed with egg yolks, gums.
- Underwent stylistic development but kept Egyptian conventions. Became more lively.
- Provided insight into Egyptian culture, values, customs for archaeologists.
- Legacy seen on papyrus scrolls, coffin cases, mummy portraits in Graeco-Roman era.

Ancient Egyptian pottery:

- Pottery was an important art form in ancient Egypt dating back to the Predynastic period starting around 5500 BCE.
- Early pottery was basic and utilitarian but became more refined in the Early Dynastic period with decorative painted designs.

- Common vessel forms were jars, bowls, jugs, pots, plates, and amphora used for storage, serving food and drink.
- Clay was abundant from the Nile. Techniques included hand building, wheel throwing, and firing.
- Surfaces were decorated with painted or incised designs depicting nature, deities, hieroglyphs, and daily life.
- Pottery was also used to make figurines, models of servants and boats placed in tombs, and canopic jars for mummified organs.
- Pottery was a marker of chronology and trade. Styles and techniques changed over time.
- In the New Kingdom, pottery became intricately glazed and colorful using materials like quartz and copper. Blue and green glazes were prized.
- Pottery provides insight into ancient Egyptian society - burial customs, trade contacts, religious symbolism, artistic skills.
- After firing, vessels were sturdy and absorbed liquids, suitable for storage and transport.

Rock paintings

Rock paintings, also known as rock art, are prehistoric or ancient works of art that are painted or drawn onto natural rock surfaces. These artworks can be found all around the world, and can range from simple geometric designs to complex depictions of animals, people, and landscapes.

Rock paintings are typically created using natural pigments such as charcoal, ochre, and other minerals, which are mixed with water or other binding agents to create a paint-like substance. The paintings are then applied to the rock surface using a variety of techniques, including brushing, spraying, and finger-painting.

Rock paintings are often found in caves, shelters, and other protected locations, and are believed to have been created for a variety of purposes. Some rock paintings may have had a religious or ceremonial significance, while others may have been used to record historical events or depict everyday life. Many rock paintings are believed to have been created during the prehistoric or ancient periods, although some have been created more recently by indigenous peoples around the world.

Rock paintings provide valuable insights into the beliefs, customs, and lifestyles of early humans and other ancient cultures, and are important cultural and historical artifacts. Many rock paintings are protected by law, and efforts are underway to preserve and study these important works of art for future generations.